KHRUSHCHEV HAD SEALED HIS SECRET DEAL WITH KENNEDY. Next on the agenda were a letter to Castro, instructions to Pliev, and a letter to U Thant. With the decision made to retreat from his public position on the missile swap announced less than twenty-four hours earlier, Khrushchev had to do some explaining and pacify his unhappy ally, instruct his military commander, and ensure the cooperation of the United Nations, which was now included in his deal with Kennedy.

"No sooner had I dictated that telegram," remembered Khrushchev, recalling the fateful meeting of the Presidium and one of the letters he sent Kennedy that day, "than we received a telegram from our ambassador transmitting a message from Castro. Fidel informed us that according to reliable information he had received, the USA would invade Cuba in a few hours." According to Khrushchev, this was the first time that he either saw the message or comprehended its sense. "What was most important in Fidel's message," recalled Khrushchev, "was not what he had been told but his conclusion: he considered that if attack was inevitable, then it had to be counteracted, and he proposed that we immediately make a first strike on the USA with nuclear missiles so that our missiles not be put out of action." According to Khrushchev, the proposal came as a shock not only to him but also to the others around the table. "When this was read to us, we, sitting in silence, looked at one another for a long time," he recalled.[22]

After some discussion, Khrushchev began dictating a letter to Castro. It was much shorter and more to the point than the official letter to Kennedy. Addressing his unruly client, Khrushchev told him: "We would like to offer the following friendly advice to you: show patience, restraint, and more restraint. Of course, if there is an invasion, then it will be necessary to repel it with all the forces at your disposal. But do not let yourselves be provoked, since the frenzied military men in the Pentagon now, at the very moment when an elimination of the conflict is taking shape to your advantage, by including a guarantee against the invasion of Cuba, seem to want to undermine the agreement and provoke you to actions which could then be used against you."[23]

It was then decided to inform U Thant immediately about the Soviet decision to dismantle the missile sites. Indeed, he was all but invited to visit missile installations during his planned trip to Cuba, and representatives of